

Research Proposal - Complexity Costs of Fault-Tolerance Circuits.

Michael Ben-Or David Ponnarovsky

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Abstract

We aim to study the overhead costs of fault-tolerant circuits in terms of both depth and width expansions. This means we ask what the optimal cost factor is, in each of the parameters alone, that one can hope to achieve, and also raise the question about the trade-off relation between the two. We ask these questions from both classical and quantum perspectives. The following proposal formulates the problems and states subproblems that might shed light on the answer.

We focus on shallow depth circuit classes, in particular, QAC_0 , $\text{QNC}_{0,f}$, QNC_1 , and 'QNC without reset gates', and certain known problem candidates for demonstrating quantum advantage such as factoring [Sho97] and Instantaneous Quantum Polynomial-time [BMS17], [Pal+24]. We aim to answer whether there exists a fault tolerance with only constant overhead at the circuit's depth. A positive answer implies that computing logarithmic depth circuits when subjected to noise is not harder than computing in an ideal environment.

1 Introduction.

The Quantum Computation model is widely believed to be superior to classical models, offering asymptotic speedup in tasks such as factoring [Sho97], searching [Gro96], simulating, and more relative to the best-known classical solutions. Yet even though there is almost complete agreement about the superiority of the ideal quantum model, there is still a debate over whether it is possible to implement complex computation in the real world, where the qubits and gates are subject to faults. Similarly, the feasibility of realizing classical computation has also been an open question. In fact the question about the feasibility of computation under noise is almost as ancient as the computer science field itself, initialized by Von Neumann [Neu56] at the time that classical computation putted in debuts. Time been pass and the followed works had pointed that not even a polynomial computation in the presence of noise is still reasonable but one can implement a fault tolerance version at a most constant times cost at the circuits depth [Pip85]. Or in asymptotic sense, classical computation in the presence of noise is as exactly hard as computation in ideal environment.

Recently, the feasibility question has been raised again, this time regarding quantum circuits, and while an intensive work has been done, and also succeed to prove that polynomial quantum computation can be made fault tolerance, [AB99],[Got14] and even with only constant overhead at the original circuit width [Gro19], polylogarithmic depth [TKY24], and logarithmic depth [NP24]. Yet the minimal required depth overhead is still not well understood. That raises our first open problem:

Open problem 1.1. Is there a fault-tolerance scheme that maps circuits to noise-tolerant versions with a depth that is at most a constant times more? If not, what is the lower bound for depth overhead?

We stress that in all the mentioned constructions, the original constant-depth gates are mapped to logical presentations whose underlying implementation has asymptotically growing depth. This is in contrast to Pippenger [Pip85], where the logical gates are $O(1)$ -depth circuits.

Such an expansion prevents any construction that merely shifts presentations without interfering with the logical computation path of the original circuits from reaching a constant

depth overhead. Previous works have made way to bypass this obstacle; notably, [Ngu24] and [Li+25] present good error correction codes with transversal **CCZ** gates, and the series of works by Bombin [BM06], [Bom10], [Bom15] yield the 2D-color and 3D-color codes, which can be embedded on low-dimensional lattices (2D and 3D) and offer transversal gate implementation, where the first offers the whole Clifford group and the second the **T** gate. However, no code with a non-trivial distance and $O(1)$ -depth implementation for a complete universal gate set is known what raises our following open problem:

Open problem 1.2. Is there an error correction code with non-trivial distance for which a full universal gate set over the logical qubits can be realized at constant depth?

Since error correction codes with trivial distance might have a constant depth realization of a universal gate set (take, for example, the code where any codeword consists of a single physical qubit that encodes the logical state, adjacent to garbage), it is also interesting to ask whether there is a turning point:

Open problem 1.3. If the answer to Open problem 1.2 is yes, what is the minimum distance for which there exists a code with that distance, and the code provides a universal gate set realization at constant depth?

Moreover, even the depth overhead is particularly interesting as today’s quantum machines are challenged to maintain quantum states for a long time. The limitations of these machines have motivated research to define NISQ, which stands for Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum, referring to the current era of quantum computing characterized by quantum processors that have a limited number of qubits and are prone to errors due to noise. In addition to NISQ, another common characterization for limited quantum computation is computation without reset gates, which has been proved to be impossible when restricted to polynomial space [Aha+96]. Having a constant depth-overhead fault tolerance scheme would imply the feasibility of log depth computation in that model.

This work addresses the above. We ask whether a magnitude depth overhead is an unavoidable price that one has to pay, If a Constant Depth Fault Tolerance Construction (CDFT) exists, and if so, how to construct it. In particular, whether an ideal $\mathbf{QNC}_1$, the class of problems that can be decided by logarithmic depth quantum circuits, can be computed in noisy- $\mathbf{QNC}_1$ circuits.

Additionally, we extend the question beyond the standard classes and ask about fault-tolerant sampling. Specifically, we consider several sampling processes by shallow quantum circuits, which are believed to be infeasible for classical circuits, such as Instantaneous Quantum Polynomial-time [BMS17], [Pal+24], and ask about the depth efficiency of their fault-tolerant version.

Classical Lower bounds [Gal91], [RS91]. [Rom06] shows that a tradeoff in model in which the given input is already encoded. Then the width overhead of the circuit is $\Theta(\frac{\log n}{\log \log n})$ while the depth overhead is $\Theta(\log \log n)$. [COMMENT] Re-write this. [KZ25], A work that studied width-depth tradeoff, and shows that codes with non-trivial rate and distance, can not offer the control-X gate for any pair of logical bits.

Something about the importance of fault tolerance computation to PCP construction. New classical [BMV24], and quantum construction [ABN24]. [PS94] Seems like a construction that based on the fact that the previous circuit was fault tolerance.

The proposal is organized as follows. ?? presents the notations, formal definitions, and states the open problems that will be studied through the research. Then, ?? describes strategies to prove CDFT. In particular, it lists primitives that can be used to achieve it and discusses how far we are from obtaining them. Having said that, ?? presents the first cues against the possibility of CDFT and provides the entry points to prove the impossibility claim. Finally, ?? discusses the applications and implications of either the correctness of CDFT or the impossibility of CDFT, from both theoretical and practical views.

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